

December

20

Spymaster

1573

English diplomat Sir Francis Walsingham became Queen Elizabeth I's principal secretary. Using spies and secret agents, he protected the Protestant monarch from several Catholic plots, and executed her main rival, Mary, Queen of Scots.



Born this day

1978 Geremi Sorele Njitap Fotso, Cameroonian footballer. He was famous for his ability to play in a number of different positions on the field.



1812

Grimm tales

German brothers Jacob and Wilhelm Grimm published their first volume of popular folk tales, *Children's and Household Tales* (later known as *Grimm's Fairy Tales*).



Also on this day

1860 The US state of South Carolina broke away from the Union, which contributed to the outbreak of the US Civil War.

1951 The EBR-1 in Idaho, USA, became the first nuclear power plant in the world to generate electricity. The power it produced lit four light bulbs.

1999 Macau was handed over to China by Portugal, ending almost 600 years of colonial control.

Rowing feat

2015

A crew of disabled military personnel set off across the Atlantic Ocean to become the first physically disabled team of four to row any ocean. It took them 46 days, 6 hours and 49 minutes in their boat *Invictus*.